had had in a long time. Maybe losing her job wouldn't turn out to be the end of the world, and something good would follow. For four years, all she'd known was Maître Mallon's office—narrow windows, the staccato click of typewriter keys, the sharp tangy smell of ink from the ribbons she constantly changed—Léa once loved it. Now, looking back, it seemed a much less pleasant way to spend her day than being out here. She took another sip of the *bernache* and placed a slice of tomato on the cornbread.

Rose huddled next to André. They looked so natural together. For an instant, Léa saw herself from a distance: a twenty-two-year-old woman looking at two people embarking on a romance, and for a split second, she wondered why she couldn't have the same life. Her father's voice came at her: "*Don't worry, Léa. I will always be here for you*." But he hadn't been, and just when she thought life without him had stabilized, her mother fell ill and Léa struggled to earn enough money to buy medicine and pay rent. After she lost her mother, she decided she couldn't open herself up to anyone—the pain and heartbreak of losing someone she loved was too great. But every now and then, she wondered if she hadn't made that choice, what kind of woman would she be now?

"Would you like some more *bernache*?" Virginie asked.

"No, thank you." Léa heard the church bells ring the time. It was already late afternoon. She was rather reluctant to leave such a convivial atmosphere, and was reassured about the LeBlanc family. She'd seen nothing in her interaction with them to indicate that they might be doing something that could get Rose in trouble. "I think we've taken up enough of your time. Thank you for your warm hospitality."

As they said goodbye and cycled back to Orléans, Léa overheard André invite Rose to the cinema.

Rose hesitated. "I don't have money for a ticket."

"That's not a problem. My friend works as a ticket seller. If the seats aren't all filled, he'll sneak us in for free. Monday seven o'clock at Place Gambetta?" André turned to Léa. "Would you like to join us?"

"That's kind, André, but I have one or two things to do, so I will decline." It wasn't strictly true, but Rose and André didn't have much time to spend with each other and Léa knew she'd be the third person out. Her confidence in André had grown, though, and she trusted him to look after her sister. "Thank you for today—we had a lovely time."